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Play yard with removable padded floor

Abstract

A play yard comprising: a play yard frame body defining an enclosed area; a tunnel located below said enclosed area; and a removable padded floor assembly. The removable padded floor assembly is removably placeable within said tunnel.

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Background/Summary

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) This invention relates to a play yard for young children. More particularly, the invention relates to a play yard that includes a removable padded floor. Most particularly, the invention relates to a play yard with a removable padded floor located in a tunnel below the lower fabric floor of the play yard such that any child within the play yard cannot access the removable padded floor.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(2) A conventional play yard or portable crib typically comprises a frame body which includes a support frame, a stand mounted on the bottom of the support frame, a fabric floor with mesh walls coming up from the support frame to create an enclosure, and a mattress secured or securable within the support frame. Thus, the play yard or portable crib has an inner space to receive an infant or a baby so that the infant or baby can play within the enclosure created by the fabric floor, mesh walls, and the support frame or so that they can sleep on the mattress.

(3) Under the current safety standard, the mattress provided with a play yard is limited in thickness which parents perceive as not comfortable enough for a child and thus have historically decided to add an additional mattress or extra padding to increase the comfort for the child. However, extra padding or an incorrectly sized mattress within the play yard or portable crib can cause safety issues. Such safety issues include entrapment of the infant between the incorrectly sized mattress or padding and the fabric floors or mesh walls of the play yard or portable crib which can lead to asphyxiation/suffocation of the infant. The safety standard requires a warning against the addition of extra padding or mattresses however, consumers continue to ignore that warning and add extra padding or incorrectly sized mattresses leading to the death of infants. There has even been a submission to the Consumer Product Safety Commission entitled "Petition Requesting Rulemaking on Supplemental Mattresses for Play Yards with Non-Rigid Sides" that requested the Commission to issue a ban on supplemental mattresses thicker than 1.5 inches for play yards with non-rigid sides because CPSC research indicates that incorrectly sized mattresses create a suffocation hazard because they create a gap between the mattress pad sides and the sides of the portable crib where a baby can suffocate when the baby's head or torso falls in such a gap while lying in a prone position.

(4) Therefore, there is a need in the art to create a play yard or portable crib that provides enhanced comfort to the infant while also not providing any opportunities for the infant to get entrapped by a mattress or padding.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(5) An embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard comprising: a play yard frame body defining an enclosed area; a tunnel located below said enclosed area; and a removable padded floor assembly; wherein the removable padded floor assembly is removably placeable within said tunnel.

(6) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein said play yard frame body includes an upper frame body and a lower frame body; wherein said upper frame body includes four vertical arms, two horizontal side arms, and two horizontal end arms; and wherein said lower frame body includes four corner brackets, four diagonal arms, two lower horizontal arms, and a release mechanism.

(7) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein each of the horizontal side and horizontal end arms are positioned and secured between two of the four vertical arms; wherein the four diagonal arms are each individually securable within one of the four corner brackets; wherein each of the four diagonal arms and the two lower horizontal arms are each individually securable within the release mechanism; and wherein each of the four vertical arms are individually securable within the four corner brackets to connect said upper frame body to said lower frame body.

(8) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein said play yard further comprises a fabric crib body comprising two side mesh walls, two end mesh walls, four horizontal padded fabric sections, four vertical fabric sections, and a lower fabric floor section.

(9) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein the four horizontal padded fabric sections surround and enclose the horizontal side and horizontal end arms; wherein the four vertical fabric sections surround and enclose the four vertical arms; wherein the lower fabric floor section provides for a lower floor portion of the enclosed area; and wherein the two side mesh walls and the two end mesh walls are surrounded by the four horizontal padded fabric sections, the four vertical fabric sections, and the lower fabric floor section to form wall portions of the enclosed area.

(10) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein the tunnel includes two tunnel side walls, two tunnel end walls, and a tunnel bottom floor, and wherein the lower fabric floor section of the enclosed area comprises an upper surface of said tunnel.

(11) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein one or both of said tunnel end walls are openable tunnel end walls, wherein one or both of said openable tunnel end walls include a stitched shut top portion, two non-stitched side portions, and a non-stitched bottom portion; wherein each said non-stitched side portion and said non-stitched bottom portion contain securement means; and wherein adjacent said securement means there are complementary securement means located on said tunnel side walls and said tunnel bottom floor.

(12) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein when said securement means on said non-stitched side portions and said non-stitched bottom portion of said one or both of said openable tunnel end walls are matted with said complementary securement means on said tunnel side walls and said tunnel bottom floor, then said one or both of said openable tunnel end walls become closed end walls.

(13) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein one or both of said tunnel side walls are openable tunnel side walls, wherein one or both of said openable tunnel side walls include a stitched shut top portion, two non-stitched side portions, and a non-stitched bottom portion; wherein each said non-stitched side portion and said non-stitched bottom portion contain securement means; and wherein adjacent said securement means there are complementary securement means located on said tunnel end walls and said tunnel bottom floor.

(14) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein when said securement means on said non-stitched side portions and said non-stitched bottom portion of said one or both of said openable tunnel side walls are matted with said complementary securement means on said tunnel end walls and said tunnel bottom floor, then said one or both of said openable tunnel side walls become closed side walls.

(15) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein said removable padded floor assembly includes a support board assembly, a foam padding assembly placed on said support board assembly, a cloth cover surrounding, and encasing said support board assembly and said foam padding assembly, and four floor securement means

located at corners of the removable padded floor assembly.

(16) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein the support board assembly is a four-piece support board assembly and wherein the foam padding assembly is a four-piece foam padding assembly.

(17) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein the tunnel bottom floor contains at least two complementary padded floor securement means located along an outside surface of the bottom floor, and wherein said floor securement means of the padded floor assembly will mate with said complementary floor securement means located along the outside surface of the bottom floor when said removable padded floor assembly is removably placed within said tunnel.

(18) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein said fabric crib body further includes a bassinet connection portion positioned along a mid-height of each of the side and end mesh walls; wherein each bassinet connection portion includes a bassinet securement means; and wherein said removable padded floor assembly includes a complementary bassinet securement means located around an upper periphery of the padded floor assembly

(19) Another embodiment of the present invention provides a play yard as in any embodiment above, wherein said bassinet securement means are removably securable with said complementary bassinet securement means of the padded floor assembly.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) For a more complete understanding of the features and advantages of the present invention, reference is now made to the detailed description of the invention along with the accompanying figures in which:

(2) FIG. 1 is a perspective view of one embodiment of the play yard with a removable padded floor of the present invention wherein the removeable padded floor is placeable through an end wall of the tunnel;

(3) FIG. 2 is a plan view of the embodiment of FIG. 1 wherein the play yard of the present invention is on its end prior to placement of the removable padded floor into the tunnel;

(4) FIG. 3A is a plan view of the embodiment of FIG. 1 wherein the play yard of the present invention is on its end after the removable padded floor has been placed within the tunnel but prior to the end wall of the tunnel being secured shut;

(5) FIG. 3B is a plan view of the embodiment of FIG. 1 wherein the play yard of the present invention is on its end after the removable padded floor has been placed within the tunnel and after the end wall of the tunnel has been secured shut;

(6) FIG. 4 is a perspective view of another embodiment of the play yard with a removable padded floor of the present invention wherein the removable padded floor is placeable through a side wall of the tunnel;

(7) FIG. 5A is a plan side view of one embodiment of the removable padded floor assembly of the play yard of the present invention;

(8) FIG. 5B is a plan side view of another embodiment of the removable padded floor assembly of the play yard of the present invention;

(9) FIG. 5C is a plan side view of yet another embodiment of the removable padded floor assembly of the play yard of the present invention;

(10) FIG. 6 is a plan view of a folded-up play yard of the present invention wherein the padded floor assembly has been removed from the tunnel;

(11) FIG. 7 is a perspective view of FIG. 6 with a padded floor assembly wrapped around the

folded play yard and secured to itself for easy storage of the play yard;

(12) FIG. 8A is a perspective view of one embodiment of the present invention with the removable padded floor not secured at the mid-height of the sides of the play yard;

(13) FIG. 8B is a perspective view of FIG. 8A with the removable padded floor secured at the mid-height of sides of the play yard such that the play yard can be used as a bassinet

(14) FIG. 8C is a locally perspective enlarged view of a corner of the play yard of FIG. 8A;

(15) FIG. 8D is a locally perspective enlarged view of the end of a track portion of the play yard of FIG. 8B; and

(16) FIG. 9 is a plan side view of one embodiment of a removable padded floor assembly to be utilized with the play yard of FIG. 8A of the present invention.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF ILLUSTRATIVE EMBODIMENTS

(17) A play yard with a removable padded floor made in accordance with the present invention is indicated by the numeral **10**. Play yard **10** comprises a frame body **12** with a fabric and/or mesh crib body **14** as shown in FIG. 1. While the present invention is not defined by the specifics of the frame body **12**, a typical frame body **12** includes an upper frame body **16** and a lower frame body **18** as shown in FIGS. 1 and 2. The upper frame body **16** includes four vertical arms **20**, two horizontal side arms **22**, and two horizontal end arms **23**. Each of the horizontal arms **22** and **23** are positioned and secured between two of the vertical arms **20**. The lower frame body **18** includes four corner brackets **24**, four diagonal arms **26**, two lower horizontal arms **28**, and a release mechanism **30**. Although not visible in the drawings of the present invention, it is contemplated that the horizontal arms **22** and **23** are two pieces arms with a locking mechanism securing the two pieces together at the center portion of each horizontal arm **22** and **23** as is common in the field.

(18) Each of the four vertical arms **20** are individually securable within the four corner brackets **24** to connect the upper frame body **16** to the lower frame body **18**. The four diagonal arms **26** are also individually securable within the four corner brackets **24** as best seen in FIG. 2. As also shown in the FIG. 2, the four diagonal arms **26** and the two lower horizontal arms **28** are also individually securable within the release mechanism **30**. The ends of the two lower horizontal arms **28** are curved to allow for easy placement on a floor surface.

(19) While the present invention is not defined by the specifics of the fabric crib body **14**, a typical fabric crib body includes two side mesh walls **32**, two end mesh walls **33**, four horizontal padded fabric sections **34**, four vertical fabric sections **36**, and a lower fabric floor section **38** as shown in FIG. 1. In some embodiments, the side mesh walls **32** and/or the end mesh walls **33** could also be made from a fabric material instead of the mesh material as shown in the drawings. The four horizontal padded fabric sections **34** surround and enclose the horizontal arms **22** and **23** and the four vertical fabric sections **36** surround and enclose the four vertical arms **20**. The lower fabric floor section **38** provides the bottom surface of the enclosed area **40** of the play yard **10** and the mesh walls **32** and **33** are surrounded by the four horizontal padded fabric sections **34**, the four vertical fabric sections **36**, and the lower fabric floor section **38**.

(20) Play yard **10** additionally includes fabric tunnel **50** located below the lower fabric floor section **38**. Tunnel **50** includes two tunnel side walls **52**, two tunnel end walls **54**, and a bottom tunnel floor **56** as best shown in FIGS. 1 and 2. In one or more embodiments of the present invention, one or both end walls **54** are openable to receive a removable padded floor assembly **60**. Within the context of the present application, the term openable as related to the end walls **54** is defined to mean that a top portion of one or both end walls **54** is secured shut with stitching **55** and the side and bottom portions of one or both end walls **54** are not secured shut. FIG. 2 shows an embodiment of the present invention wherein an end wall **54** is in an opened position to receive a padded floor assembly **60**. When one or more end walls **54** are openable, the sides and bottom portion of the openable end wall **54** will contain securement means **57a**, with a related securement means **57b** located adjacent the sides of the side wall **52** and along a bottom portion of the bottom floor **56** as best shown in FIGS. 3A and 3B. In one or more embodiments, the securement means **57a** and **57b**

can include a hook and loop type fasteners, male and female snap fasteners, and male and female zip fasteners.

(21) In one or more embodiments of the present invention, one or both side walls **52** are openable to receive a removable padded floor assembly **60** as best shown in FIG. **4**. Within the context of the present application, the term openable as related to the side walls **52** is defined to mean that a top portion of one or both side walls **52** is secured shut with stitching **58** and the side and bottom portions of one or both side walls **52** are not secured shut. FIG. **4** shows wherein a side wall **52** is in an opened position to receive a padded floor assembly. When one or more side walls **52** are openable, the sides and bottom portion of the side wall **52** will contain a securement means **59a**, with a related securements means **59b** located adjacent the sides of the side wall **52** and along a bottom portion of the bottom floor **56** as best shown in FIG. **4**. In one or more embodiments, the securement means **59a** and **59b** can include hook and loop type fasteners, male and female snap fasteners, and male and female zip fasteners.

(22) FIGS. **5A**, **5B**, and **5C** show three different embodiments of the padded floor assembly **60**. In every embodiment of the padded floor assembly **60**, said assembly **60** is comprised of four main elements: cloth cover **62**, foam padding assembly **64**, support board assembly **66**, and securement means **68a**. In one or more embodiments of the present invention, the padded floor assembly will also include at least one handle **70** located along at least one of the sides or along at least one of ends of the padded floor assembly **60**.

(23) As shown in FIG. **5A**, this embodiment of the padded floor assembly **60** includes a one-piece foam padding assembly **64** and a one-piece support board assembly **66**. The one-piece foam padding assembly **64** and the one-piece support board assembly **66** are contained within the cloth covering **62**. Although only two securement means **68a** are shown adjacent the corners of the assembly **60**, it is contemplated that the padded floor assembly **60** of FIG. **5A** also has two additional securement means located adjacent the other corners of the assembly **60**.

(24) As shown in FIG. **5B**, this embodiment of the padded floor assembly **60** includes a two-piece foam padding assembly **64a** and a two-piece support board assembly **66a**. It is important to note that in the embodiment of FIG. **5B**, the two-piece foam padding assembly **64a**, although separated into two pieces of foam padding, will operate in a comparable manner to the one-piece foam padding assembly shown in FIG. **5A** when unfolded to a flat orientation. In a comparable manner, the two-piece support board assembly **66a**, although separated into two pieces of support board, will operate in a comparable manner to the one-piece support board portion as shown in FIG. **5A** when unfolded to a flat orientation. The assemblies **64a** and **66a** are contained within a cloth cover **62**. The cloth cover **62** additionally includes stitching **65**, located on the underside of the cloth cover **62**, to split the padded floor assembly **60** into two attached but separate portions. Although only two securement means **68a** are shown adjacent the corners of the assembly **60**, it is contemplated that the padded floor assembly **60** of FIG. **5B** also has two additional securement means located adjacent the other corners of the assembly **60**.

(25) As shown in FIG. **5C**, this embodiment of the padded floor assembly **60** includes a four-piece segmented foam assembly **64b** and a four-piece segmented support board assembly **66b**. It is important to note that in the embodiment of FIG. **5C**, the four-piece foam padding assembly **64b**, although separated into four pieces of foam padding, will operate in a comparable manner to the one-piece foam padding assembly of FIG. **5A** when unfolded to a flat orientation. In a comparable manner, the four-piece support board assembly **66b**, although separated into four pieces of support board, will operate in a comparable manner to the one-piece support board portion of FIG. **5A** when unfolded to a flat orientation. The assemblies **64b** and **66b** are contained within a cloth cover **62**. The cloth cover **62** additionally includes stitching **65a**, **65b**, and **65c**, located on the underside of cloth cover **62**, to split the padded floor assembly **60** into four attached but separate pieces. Although only two securement means **68a** are shown adjacent the corners of the assembly **60**, it is contemplated that the padded floor assembly **60** of FIG. **5C** also has two additional securement

means located adjacent the other corners of the assembly **60**.

(26) The padded floor assembly **60** will include positions where securement means **68a** are located. If the play yard **10** is designed to have the padded floor assembly **60** placed within the tunnel **50** through the end walls **54**, then the padded floor assembly **60** will include two securement means **68a** along each end portion of the padded floor assembly **60**, such as shown in FIGS. 5A, 5B, and 5C. If the play yard **10** is designed to have the padded floor assembly **60** be placed within the tunnel **50** through the side walls **52**, then the padded floor assembly **60** will include two securement means **68a** along each side portion of the padded floor assembly. In the embodiment shown in FIGS. 3A and 3B, the padded floor assembly **60** includes securement means **68a**, with a related securements means **68b** located along a bottom portion of the bottom floor **56**. In one or more embodiments, the securement means **68a** and **68b** can include hook and loop type fasteners, male and female snap fasteners, and male and female zip fasteners. While both end portions of the padded floor assembly **60**, or both side portions of the padded floor assembly **60** may include securement means **68a** and **68b**, it will only be necessary to secure one end or one side of the padded floor assembly **60** to secure assembly **60** within the tunnel **50** of the play yard **10**.

(27) The padded floor assembly **60** is oriented within the play yard **10** such that the foam assembly **64/64a/64b** is closest to any child within the interior of play yard **10**, when the play yard **10** is being used as either a play yard cover or a bassinet. In one or more embodiments of the present invention, the thickness of the padded floor assembly **60**, including the foam assembly **64/64a/64b**, the support board assembly **66/66a/66b**, and the cloth cover **62** is from 0.5 inches to 4.0 inches, in other embodiments from 1.0 inches to 3.75 inches, and in yet other embodiments from 2.0 inches to 3.0 inches. In other embodiments, the thickness is greater than 0.5 inches, in other embodiments greater than 1.0 inches, and in yet other embodiments greater than 2.0 inches. In other embodiments, the thickness is less than 4.0 inches, in other embodiments less than 3.75 inches, and in yet other embodiments less than 3.25 inches. In other embodiments, the thickness of the padded floor assembly **60**, including the foam assembly **64/64a/64b**, the support board assembly **66/66a/66b**, and the cloth cover **62** is 3.0 inches.

(28) To set up play yard **10** for use, the following steps should be taken. To set up the enclosed area **40** of the play yard **10**, the center of each horizontal side arm **22** needs to be grabbed and lifted upwards until the horizontal side arms **22** are in their fully extended and locked positions. Next, the center of each horizontal end arm **23** needs to be grabbed and lifted upwards until the horizontal end arms **23** are in their fully extended and locked positions. Next, the release mechanism **30** needs pushed down on until it locks the lower frame body **18** in place, this will set up the enclosed area **40** of the play yard **10**.

(29) Once the enclosed area **40** of play yard **10** has been setup, the next step is to install the padded floor assembly **60** within tunnel **50**. In one or more embodiments, the play yard **10** is set on its end as shown in FIGS. 2 and 3 if the padded floor assembly **60** is to be installed through a tunnel end wall **54**, or on its side if the padded floor assembly **60** is to be installed through a tunnel side wall **52**. Next, by grabbing a handle **70** of the padded floor assembly **60**, the padded floor assembly **60** can be slid into position within the tunnel **50**. It is important to note that the padded floor assembly **60** should be slid within the tunnel **50** such that the foam padding **64** is positioned to be adjacent the lower fabric floor section **38** which also acts as the top wall of tunnel **50**. Once in place, the securement means **68a** should be secured to the securement means **68b** as shown in FIGS. 3A and 3B. The last step of setting up play yard **10** for use is to secure the securement means **57a** along sides and bottom portion of end wall **54** with the related securement means **57b** located adjacent the sides of the side walls **52** and along a bottom portion of the bottom floor **56** to close access to tunnel **50** as best shown in FIG. 3B.

(30) To take apart play yard **10** when not in use, the first step will be to remove the padded floor assembly **60** from within tunnel **50** by placing the play yard **10** on its end as shown in FIG. 2, unsecuring the securement means **57a** and **57b**, unsecuring the securement means **68a** and **68b**,

grabbing padded floor assembly **60** by handle **70** and pulling said assembly **60** from the tunnel **50**. Once removed, the next step will be to push up on release mechanism **30** of the lower frame body **18** and release the locking mechanisms on the horizontal arms **22** and **23** to then allow for the frame body **12** to fold up as shown in FIG. **6**.

(31) In embodiments of the present invention that utilize the padded floor assembly **60** as shown in FIG. **5C**, there is an additional step that can take place when storing the play yard **10** when not in use. The padded floor assembly **60** including the four-piece segmented foam assembly **64b** and a four-piece segmented support board assembly **66b** can be wrapped around the folded-up frame body **12** and fabric crib body **14** as shown in FIG. **7**. The padded floor assembly **60** of FIG. **5C** also includes two different securement means **72a** and **72b** that can be utilized to secure the padded floor assembly **60** when placed around the folded-up play yard **10** when it is not in use. In one or more embodiments, the securement means **72a** and **72b** can include hook and loop type fasteners, male and female snap fasteners, and male and female zip fasteners.

(32) Although not shown in any of the drawings, it is also contemplated that a removable mattress can be supplied with the play yard **10** of the present invention that would be placeable on top of the lower fabric floor section **38** of the enclosed area **40** of the play yard **10**. This mattress would be relatively thin to not provide any opportunity for a child/infant to become entrapped underneath and cause a safety hazard. It is contemplated that such a mattress will be less than 1 inch thick and would also have the ability to receive a fitted sheet.

(33) In one embodiment of the present invention, the padded floor assembly **60** can also be secured in a position such that the play yard can be used as a bassinet. As shown in FIGS. **8A** and **8B**, the play yard **100** has all of the same features of play yard **10** as shown in FIG. **1**. However, play yard **100** additionally has four bassinet connection portions **39** located at about the mid-height of each of the mesh walls **32** and **33**. Also located along the interior portion of the four bassinet connections portions **39** is a zipper track **51a**. As shown in FIG. **9**, the padded floor assembly **60** of this embodiment will also contain a corresponding zipper track **51b** located around the external upper periphery of the padded floor assembly **60**. Although the padded floor assembly of FIG. **9** is similar to the padded floor assembly **60** of FIG. **5A**, it is also contemplated that padded floor assembly **60** as shown in FIGS. **5B** and **5C** can contain a zipper track **51b** located around its external upper periphery.

(34) Although the above section discusses the use of zippers **51a** and **51b** to secure the padded floor assembly **60** into the play yard **100**, the present invention also contemplates other securement means such as hook and loop type fasteners and male and female snap fasteners.

(35) The zipper track **51a** as shown is a male zipper track while the zipper track **51b** as shown in the figures is a female zipper track, however, it is contemplated that the zipper track **51a** could be a female zipper track while the zipper track **51b** could be a male zipper track. By male zipper track, the present invention is referring to the portion of a zipper assembly that includes a stationary end and an insert pin and by female zipper track, the present invention is referring to the portion of a zipper assembly that includes a zipper slider **61**. Although the above sections discuss the use of zippers **51a** and **51b** to secure the padded floor assembly **60** into a bassinet mode in play yard **100**, the present invention also contemplates other securement means such as hook and loop type fasteners and male and female snap fasteners.

(36) FIG. **8A-8D** of the present invention show that the zipper track **51b** around the upper external periphery of the padded floor assembly **60** includes two zipper sliders **61**, located at opposite ends of the of the padded floor assembly **60**. The two zipper sliders **61** on the zipper track **51b** will correspond with two separate portions of the zipper tracks **51a** of the play yard **100**. The present invention also contemplated that the zipper track **51b** could include just one zipper slider, which would correspond with just one portion of the zipper track **51a**; or in other embodiments, there could be four zipper sliders, one for each portion of the bassinet connection portions **39**, which would then correspond with four separate portions of the zipper tracks **51a**.

(37) As shown in FIG. 8C, above the position of zipper tracks **51a** is a flap of material **71** that will cover the zipper assembly of **51a** and **51b** when the padded floor assembly **60** is in a bassinet position. The flap of material **71** will hide the zipper assembly of **51a** and **51b** such that an infant cannot easily access it. FIG. 8C specifically shows a corner of the play yard **100** wherein an additional piece of material **53** is located that provides the user of the play yard **100** with a curved corner to make securing of the padded floor assembly **60** easier when securing the zipper assembly of **51a** and **51b** around the corners of play yard **100**. Although FIG. 8C shows only one corner located between two portions of the four bassinet connections portions **39**, the present invention contemplates that each corner between each portion of the four bassinet connections portions **39** will contain an additional piece of material **53**.

(38) FIG. 8D shows the end of a portion of a zipper track **51a** secured to corresponding zipper track **51b**. A small pocket **80** will be formed at the area shown in FIG. 8D when the zipper portions are connected that will allow for the zipper slider **61** to be tucked away therewithin to prevent occupants of the play yard **100** from accessing the zipper slider **61**. To further prevent any tampering with the zipper slider **61**, a clasp **82** is secured near the end of each portion of zipper track **51a**. The clasp **82** will connect with the zipper slider **61** and then both the clasp **82** and the zipper slider **61** will be tucked into pocket **80**. Therefore, in embodiments of the present invention wherein there are two zipper sliders **61**, there will be two corresponding pockets **80** and two corresponding clasps **82** that will work with the zipper sliders **61** once the padded floor assembly **60** has been set in place.

(39) To place the padded floor assembly **60** into a bassinet position, such as shown in FIG. 8B, the padded floor assembly **60** will need to be secured to the play yard **100**. To do this, the zipper track **51b** along the external upper periphery of the padded floor assembly **60** will need to mate with zipper track **51a** located along the interior portion of the four bassinet connection portions **39**. After securing zipper track **51b** with **51a** by zipping the one or more zipper sliders **61** to the one or more ends of zipper track **51a**, the one or more zipper sliders **61** are connected to a clasp **82** and then tucked into a pocket **80**. Once zipper track **51b** is secured to zipper track **51a** along the external upper periphery of the padded floor assembly **60**, the play yard **100** of the present invention is ready to be used in bassinet mode.

(40) Considering the foregoing, it should be appreciated that the present invention significantly advances the art by providing a play yard with a removable padded floor that is structurally and functionally improved in several ways. While particular embodiments of the invention have been disclosed in detail herein, it should be appreciated that the invention is not limited thereto or thereby since variations on the invention herein will be readily appreciated by those of ordinary skill in the art. The scope of the invention shall be appreciated from the claims that follow.

Claims

1. A play yard comprising: a play yard frame and fabric crib body defining an enclosed area, wherein the fabric crib body of the enclosed area includes two side mesh walls, two end mesh walls, and a lower fabric floor; a padded floor encasement located below the two side mesh walls, the two end mesh walls, and the lower fabric floor, wherein the padded floor encasement includes two padded floor encasement side walls, two padded floor encasement end walls, and a padded floor encasement bottom floor, wherein the lower fabric floor of the enclosed area comprises an upper surface of said padded floor encasement, wherein one or both of said padded floor encasement end walls are openable padded floor encasement end walls, and wherein one or both of said openable padded floor encasement end walls include a stitched shut top portion; and a removable padded floor assembly; wherein the removable padded floor assembly is removably placeable within said padded floor encasement and configured to be positioned adjacent to and beneath the lower fabric floor section.

2. The play yard of claim 1, wherein said play yard frame body includes an upper frame body and a lower frame body; wherein said upper frame body includes four vertical arms, two horizontal side arms, and two horizontal end arms; and wherein said lower frame body includes four corner brackets, four diagonal arms, two lower horizontal arms, and a release mechanism.
3. The play yard of claim 2, wherein each of the horizontal side and horizontal end arms are positioned and secured between two of the four vertical arms; wherein the four diagonal arms are each individually securable within one of the four corner brackets; wherein each of the four diagonal arms and the two lower horizontal arms are each individually securable within the release mechanism; and wherein each of the four vertical arms are individually securable within the four corner brackets to connect said upper frame body to said lower frame body.
4. The play yard of claim 3, wherein said fabric crib body further includes four horizontal padded fabric sections and four vertical fabric sections.
5. The play yard of claim 4, wherein the four horizontal padded fabric sections surround and enclose the horizontal side and horizontal end arms; wherein the four vertical fabric sections surround and enclose the four vertical arms; wherein the lower fabric floor provides for a lower floor portion of the enclosed area; and wherein the two side mesh walls and the two end mesh walls are surround by the four horizontal fabric sections, the four vertical fabric sections, and the lower fabric floor to form wall portions of the enclosed area.
6. The play yard of claim 4, wherein said fabric crib body further includes a bassinet connection portion positioned along a mid-height of each of the side and end mesh walls; wherein each bassinet connection portion includes a bassinet securement means; and wherein said removable padded floor assembly includes a complementary bassinet securement means located around an upper periphery of the padded floor assembly.
7. The play yard of claim 6, wherein said bassinet securement means are removably securable with said complementary bassinet securement means of the padded floor assembly.
8. The play yard of claim 1, wherein one or both of said openable padded floor encasement end walls further include two non-stitched side portions, and a non-stitched bottom portion; wherein each said non-stitched side portion and said non-stitched bottom portion contain securement means; and wherein adjacent said securement means are complementary securement means located on said padded floor encasement side walls and said padded floor encasement bottom floor.
9. The play yard of claim 8, wherein when said securement means on said non-stitched side portions and said non-stitched bottom portion of said one or both of said openable padded floor encasement end walls are matted with said complementary securement means on said padded floor encasement side walls and said padded floor encasement bottom floor, then said one or both of said openable padded floor encasement end walls become closed end walls.
10. The play yard of claim 1, wherein one or both of said padded floor encasement side walls are openable padded floor encasement side walls, wherein one or both of said openable padded floor encasement side walls include a stitched shut top portion, two non-stitched side portions, and a non-stitched bottom portion; wherein each said non-stitched side portion and said non-stitched bottom portion contain securement means; and wherein adjacent said securement means are complementary securement means located on said padded floor encasement end walls and said padded floor encasement bottom floor.
11. The play yard of claim 10, wherein when said securement means on said non-stitched side portions and said non-stitched bottom portion of said one or both of said openable padded floor encasement side walls are matted with said complementary securement means on said padded floor encasement end walls and said padded floor encasement bottom floor, then said one or both of said openable padded floor encasement side walls become closed side walls.
12. The play yard of claim 1, wherein said removable padded floor assembly includes a support board assembly, a foam padding assembly placed on said support board assembly, a cloth cover surrounding, and encasing said support board assembly and said foam padding assembly, and four

floor securement means located at corners of the removable padded floor assembly.

13. The play yard of claim 12, wherein the support board assembly is a four-piece support board assembly and wherein the foam padding assembly is a four-piece foam padding assembly.

14. The play yard of claim 12, wherein the padded floor encasement bottom floor contains at least two complementary padded floor securement means located along an outside surface of the bottom floor, and wherein said floor securement means of the padded floor assembly will mate with said complementary floor securement means located along the outside surface of the bottom floor when said removable padded floor assembly is removably placed within said padded floor encasement.

15. A play yard comprising: a play yard frame and fabric crib body defining an enclosed area, wherein the fabric crib body of the enclosed area includes two side mesh walls, two end mesh walls, and a lower fabric floor; a padded floor encasement located below the two side mesh walls, the two end mesh walls, and the lower fabric floor, wherein the padded floor encasement includes two padded floor encasement side walls, two padded floor encasement end walls, and a padded floor encasement bottom floor, wherein the lower fabric floor section of the enclosed area comprises an upper surface of said padded floor encasement, wherein one or both of said padded floor encasement side walls are openable padded floor encasement side walls, and wherein one or both of said openable padded floor encasement side walls include a stitched shut top portion; and a removable padded floor assembly; wherein the removable padded floor assembly is removably placeable within said padded floor encasement and configured to be positioned adjacent to and beneath the lower fabric floor section.
